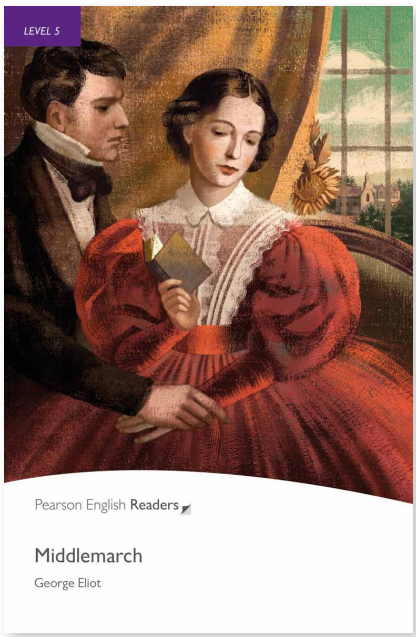


PREPARATION

1 **Answer the questions.**

see

1 What life event do you associate with the picture?

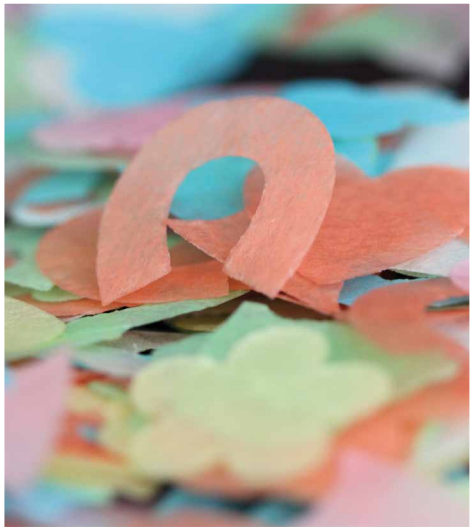
think

2 What do you think is the ideal age to get married?

3 What do you think is the maximum age difference between the two people for a good marriage?

wonder

4 What effect would it have on a couple if they had a 25-year age gap?



Her husband's last request

'I have a request to make, Dorothea,' said Mr Casaubon to his wife one night as they got into bed, 'Please let me know that if I die you will obey my wishes. Will you do as I ask?' Dorothea did not answer immediately.

'Do you refuse?' he asked anxiously.

'No, I don't yet refuse,' said Dorothea 'but I can't promise when I don't know what you want me to do. Can you wait until tomorrow?'

'Until tomorrow then,' said Mr Casaubon.

While her husband slept, Dorothea imagined the months and years ahead of her, sorting through his dusty notes to produce a book that had no academic value. She had married him to help with his life's work, when she had thought the work was something greater. If he lived for fifteen more years, she would spend her marriage helping him and obeying him. She lay awake half the night, feeling ill and helpless.

As she went downstairs to breakfast the next morning, she had made up her mind to give him the answer that he wanted.

'I am not feeling well, my dear,' said Mr Casaubon when he saw her. 'I am going out to walk in the garden. What is your answer?'

'May I come out to the garden soon, my dear,' she said.

'I will wait for you there,' he said. Dorothea drank a cup of tea, but could not eat breakfast. She sat quietly, thinking of the living hell that lay before her, knowing she was too weak to refuse. She would promise, and then she would have to keep her promise. Finally, she went out into the garden. Her husband sat at a stone table, his head resting on his arms.

'Look how tired he is,' she thought. 'I am here, Edward,' she said, sitting down next to him. 'I am ready to promise.'

She tried to wake him from his sleep, but he did not move. 'Edward! Edward!' she cried, shaking him.

But it was too late. Mr Casaubon was dead.

COMPREHENSION

2 LL10.01 **Listen and read the text, then complete the summary with the words in the box. There are two extra words you do not need.**

garden	promise	value	refuse
wishes	marriage	obey	

One day, Mr Casaubon asks his wife to follow his [1]..... . She spends a sleepless night thinking about her old hopes for her [2]..... . She had hoped to help him write a book of great [3]..... but this now seems unlikely to happen. Next morning, she decides that she will not [4]..... his request, despite not knowing what he will ask her to do. However, before he can tell her more, he dies in their [5]..... .

LISTENING

3 LL10.02 **Listen to what Mr Casaubon meant when he said he wanted Dorothea to obey his wishes after he died. What did his will say?**

GLOSSARY

will *n.* a piece of paper that says who you want your belongings to be given to after you die

spidery *adj.* handwriting that is hard to read

twist *v.* to turn suddenly

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

4A **There have been many strange requests made in wills. Find out what these people requested in their wills. Which one is the strangest?**

1 Henry Budd's will in 1842
2 Frederic Baur in 2008
3 Wellington Burt in 1919
4 Mark Gruenwald in 1996

B **One of the themes of Middlemarch is that marriage is not always romantic and perfect, and can be hard.**

1 How old were Dorothea and Mr Casaubon when they married?

SPEAKING

5 **Discuss with a partner. After reading the extract, what do you think about the following?**

1 How had the age difference affected their marriage?
2 How did they both feel about their marriage?
3 How do your answers to questions 1 and 2 compare with your answer in THINK question 1?
4 What might have happened to make Mr Casaubon put Will Ladislaw in his will?

CLIL CONNECTION

Literature

6 **George Eliot is a pen name. Find out the real name of the author of *Middlemarch*.**

1 What is surprising about the real author?
2 Why did the writer use a pen name for their novels?
3 Find out why these famous writers used a pen name for some of their books. What pen name did they use, why did they use one, and how was the truth discovered?
   a) J.K. Rowling
   b) Stephen King
   c) Isaac Asimov

